

Department of Art & Visual Culture

Strategic Plan – 2024-2029

Updated March 28, 2025

Vision Statement:

"The Department of Art & Visual Culture will cultivate an engaging, comprehensive, and dynamic learning environment, preparing students to impact the world through research and creative practices in the visual arts."

Mission Statement:

"The mission of the Department of Art and Visual Culture is to uphold and advocate for the visual arts across the university and our wider communities. We educate our students in both traditional and innovative materials and techniques and in art's global histories, nurturing their innovation in creative practices and research while fostering appreciation for the importance of art to science, to history, to community-building, and to leading vibrant, engaged lives in contemporary society."

Our values:

We value curiosity and a willingness to take risks; understanding of historical and contemporary global art; research as creative inquiry; investigation and experimentation with materials and technologies; collaboration and collegiality; community engagement; communication skills; compassion, reflection, and self-discovery.

Strategic Issues & Program Goals	Objectives & Actions
Support Student Learning and Professional Development	1. Expand and promote high-impact, experiential, service learning, study abroad, and internship opportunities. 2. Recruit, support, and graduate passionate and curious, undergraduate and graduate students, in alignment with our community's values.¹ 3. Incorporate professional development into all stages of the curriculum, including through an AVC learning community, student-led and juried exhibitions, and networking opportunities with industry partners and other professionals.

¹ This point was adjusted in spring 2025 in response to ISU requirement.

	4. Partner with local and regional galleries and nonprofit creative workspaces to offering current students and recent alumni support, including through internships and subsidized professional studio space. 5. Promote student engagement in Iowa State University events and in external conferences and exhibitions; 6. Develop high-visibility, collaborative student projects such as annual shared sketchbooks and DIY pop-up exhibitions or projections. 7. Promote, expand, and support through scholarships international study. 8. Develop and cultivate interdisciplinary course offerings, including co-taught Interdisciplinary Studios, and encourage cross-disciplinary collaborations among students within the department, college, and university. 9. Recognized visiting artists and scholars give workshops, lectures, and presentations. 10. Actively mentor students as they navigate their programs of study, helping them to articulate and actualize their learning goals and professional development.
Support and enrich faculty research, scholarship, and recognition	1. Recruit, retain, and promote high-quality, innovative faculty on both research and teaching tracks, in alignment with our community's values.² 2. Support all faculty through professional development and formal mentoring opportunities at all ranks. 3. Promote and nurture faculty recognition through internal and external award nominations. 4. Promote, publicize, and celebrate faculty achievements. 5. Develop tactics to engage students in faculty research and creative activities. 6. Organize and support biennial, on-campus faculty exhibitions. 7. Cultivate community, creativity, and collegiality through shared, informal events. 8. Promote equitable workloads through a culture of transparency and open communication about the department's teaching and service needs.
Propagate Connections and Fulfill Land Grant Mission	1. Collaborate with college, campus, and community partners in teaching, research, and program development. 2. Support and encourage collaborative teaching and research, including with Iowa State University Extension and Outreach, Community and Economic Development (CED).

² This point was adjusted in spring 2025 in response to ISU requirement.

	3. Develop and promote an artist-in-residence program. 4. Develop and advance community-engaged curricula. 5. Partner with community colleges to ease transfer pathways into AVC programs.
Advance Innovation through State-of-the-Art Facilities	1. Invest in state-of-the-art facilities across all media areas. 2. Collaborate and partner with departments within the College of Design to rethink and re-envision studio spaces. 3. Upgrade and improve existing facilities with current technologies to ensure optimal functionality, create a welcoming aesthetic, and facilitate student success. 4. Create additional informal spaces for critique, review, and collaboration, supporting and boosting morale for faculty and students. 5. Collaborate with the Student Innovation Center (SICTR) to access large-scale labs for teaching modules, leveraging these technologies together with those in existing studio spaces for student success and learning. 6. Partner with wider university community, local and regional galleries, and nonprofit creative workspaces to facilitate access to individual or shared studio spaces for undergraduate and graduate students, advancing the students' professional development and network, and increasing visibility of department.
Build Strong Alumni- and Community Partnerships	1. Connect with alumni community through regular newsletters and events, sharing alumni, faculty, and current student achievements. 2. Use social media and web-based communications to feature student and faculty work and to inform and update students and stakeholders about the events and opportunities in the Art & Visual Culture Department. 3. Maintain active Advisory Council to advance curricular developments that respond to industry trends and to connect with stakeholders and wider arts communities. 4. Bring arts professionals and scholars to campus to inspire current students, attract and recruit new students, and promote a healthy visual arts community. 5. Partner with ISU Foundation to design a donor structure that accommodates, prioritizes, and honors donations large and small.